



Ludovic Mompelat – Purdue Linguistics Symposium 2022 - April 9th, 2022

Finiteness in Atlantic Creoles Revisited

Mufwene & Dijkhoff (1989)

1. “There is no finite/non-finite distinction, hence no infinitive, in the basilects of Atlantic Pidgins and Creoles”
 - Haitian creole, Papiamentu, Gullah, Jamaican, Providencia, and Sranan.
 - Influential in Creolistics and esp. for French-based Creoles

2. **Koopman (1986)** : “a finite clause contains a finite verb or INFL and a lexical subject; an infinitival clause does not contain a finite verb or INFL and cannot - usually - contain a lexical subject.”
 - Infinitival constructions correspond to embedded sentences with a null subject and an empty COMP/CP
 - Mufwene & Dijkhoff sought to present counter-arguments against this definition focusing on the complementation system (purposive clauses and “*that*” clauses)

3. **Mufwene & Dijkhoff (1989)** : an infinitive is “one of those *inflections* which verbs assume when used in some prototypically nominal or non-verbal functions”
 - Absence of verbal inflection → justifies the absence of infinitive
 - No overt morphology → No AGR features on the verb → no PRO/pro distinction



Proposal

Reanalyze the data presented in Mufwene & Dijkhoff's 1989 article on Haitian creole (HC) and Papiamentu (Pp) in view of new analyses regarding the notion of finiteness.

1. Is there really no finite/non-finite distinction in Atlantic Creoles?
2. Is Koopman's definition of finiteness viable given our reanalysis?
3. Can we really do away with the pro/PRO distinction for HC and Pp?



Haitian Creole & Papiamentu

1. French-based creole & Spanish/Portuguese-based creole
2. No inflectional marking of tense and person agreement on Verbs
 - Instead, TMA markers as separate morphemes
 - Pronouns do not mark case agreement
3. Papiamentu & Haitian creole considered to be pro-drop languages (Hofherr 2006, Rizzi 1986)
 - Pp : Allowing pro-drop for non-referential, arbitrary, and 3PL iff antecedent present in the main clause. (Kouwenberg & Scott 2010)
 - HC : Allowing pro-drop for non-referential null subject (weather, existential, etc.) (DeGraff 1993)
4. Purposive preposition *pa* and *pou* → “in order to”/ “so that ...” (= *pa/pou*-purposive)
5. Homonymous *Pa* and *pou* are also complementizers → “that” (= *pa/pou*-Comp)



Haitian Creole & Papiamentu



Complementizers *pa* and *pou*

1. Verbs selecting *pa/pou*-Comp

- Predicates selecting obligatory control complements
- Desideratives/emotives (to prefer, to want, to wish, to desire, to see to, to ask, to order...)
- Factive (To like, to fear, to request...)

Predicates selecting Exhaustive control complements

Implicatives	(dare, manage, forget, ...)
Aspectual	(begin, stop, continue, ...)
Modal	(able, capable, need, must, ...)

Predicates selecting Partial control complements

Desiderative	(want, prefer, decide, ...)
Interrogative	(wonder, ask, guess, ...)
Factive	(hate, regret, dislike, ...)
Propositional	(believe, imagine, say, ...)

Landau 2004, p.835

That-like complementizers

Marie _i	souhaite	qu'	elle _{i*/j}	vienne	Fr
Maria _i	quiere	que	(ella _{i*/j})	venga	Sp
Mary _i	wishes	that	she _{i/j}	came	En
Mari _i	lé	pou	l _{i/j}	vini	HC
Maria _i	ke	pa	e _{i/j}	bin	Pp



(Re)defining finiteness

Go beyond the morphological concept of finiteness

1. Bianchi's (2003) logophoric & temporal centers
2. Landau's (2004) [+/- T][+/-Agr][+/-R] features on CP and IP
3. Adger's (2007) truncation at CP and TP
4. Mittwoch (1990) bare-VP:

"I heard/saw Mary slam the door"

"I made/let John cross the street"

- No C or T
- No case assigning
- No infinitival marker
- No tense agreement
- No complementizer
- Anaphoric tense
- Negation not freely permitted

Independent temporal reference = event of embedded clause is separate from event of main clause.

*Yesterday, John began to solve the problem tomorrow. *asp.*

*Yesterday, John was able to solve the problem tomorrow. *mod.*

Yesterday, John hoped to solve the problem tomorrow. *des.*

Yesterday, John wondered how to solve the problem tomorrow. *int.*

Complement types	Characteristics
Indicatives	Independent tense/ Overt agreement / <i>pro</i> &Lexical DP
Subjunctives	Dependent tense/ Overt agreement / <i>pro</i> &Lexical DP
Partial Control	Dependent tense/ Covert agreement / PRO
Exhaustive control	Anaphoric tense / Covert agreement / PRO
ECM/Raising	Dependent tense/ AGR deficient / <i>pro</i> &Lexical DP (via <i>t</i>)



Haitian Creole

“Infinitival constructions correspond to embedded sentences with a null subject and an empty COMP”

Koopman (1986) applying finiteness tests for *pou*-Comp complements :

1. Wh-extraction test
 - If subject is wh-extracted, *ki* must be inserted in the CP of extraction site
2. Distribution of anaphors
 - “One ... the other”. “The other” needs to be bound in its binding domain

Jan vlé [Mari vini] John wants Mary come ‘John wants Mary to come.’

Ki mounn _i Jan vlé [t_i vini]? Which person John wants come ‘Who does John wants to come?’

*Ki mounn _i Jan vlé [ki_i vini]?

Jan vlé [pou Mari vini] John wants COMP Mary come ‘John wants Mary to come.’
--

Ki mounn _i Jan vlé [pou ki_i vini]? Which person John wants COMP RES come ‘Who does John wants to come?’
--

yun vlé [(*pou) lot fè-tet-li] one wants COMP other shave
--

Lefebvre 1998, p.289

Koopman 1986, p.237



Mufwene & Dijkhoff's objections

1. **Issue** : Circuitous and aprioristic to apply wh-extraction test to determine whether a clause contains an infinitive/inflection on the verb & Anaphor test does not work for complements of intransitive verb

Proposal : Look at other properties such as TMA marking, negation, referentiality

2. **Issue** : Invoking embeddedness and subjectlessness to define an infinitival clause is arbitrary.



The case of *pou*-Comp in HC

Without complementizer	With complementizer
Mari_i vlé [PRO_{i/*j} vini] Mary wants PRO come “Mary wants to come” Mari_i vlé I_{*i/j} [PRO_j vini] Mary wants (3SG) PRO come “Mary wants her to come”	*Mari_i vlé [pu PRO_i vini] Mary wants COMP PRO come “Mary wants to come” Mari_i vlé [pu I_{i/j} vini] Mary wants COMP 3SG come “Mary wants her to come”
Covert subject is controlled No overt lexical subject allowed	Overt subject is referentially free No covert controlled subject
Independent temporal reference	Independent temporal reference
No TMA markers allowed	Perfective/Past marker <i>te</i> allowed
No negation allowed	Negation is allowed
- Landau's Obligatory control - Adger's CP/IP-truncated → Non-finite clause	- Subjunctive-like properties → Finite clause

Sterlin 1989, p.137

Partial Control

Dependent tense / Abstract agreement / PRO

Subjunctives

Dependent tense / Overt agreement / *pro* & lexicalDP

- Behavior seen from wh-extraction and anaphor tests is expected
- There is a point in keeping the distinction finite/non-finite



The case of *pa*-Comp in Pp

Without complementizer	With complementizer
Mari_i ke [PRO_{i/*j} piki koko] Mary wants PRO pick coconuts “Mary wants to pick coconuts” Mari_i ke e_{i/j} [PRO_j piki koko] Mary wants (3SG) PRO pick coconuts “Mary wants her to pick coconuts”	Mari_i ke [pa PRO_{arb} piki koko] Mary wants COMP PRO pick coconuts “Mary wants coconuts to be picked” Mari_i ke [pa e_{i/j} piki koko] Mary wants COMP she pick coconuts “Mary wants (her) to pick coconuts”
Covert subject is controlled No overt lexical subject allowed	Overt subject is referentially free Covert subject is arbitrary → pro-drop (Kouwenberg & Scott 2010)
Independent temporal reference	Independent temporal reference
Perfective/Past marker <i>a</i> allowed	Perfective/Past marker <i>a</i> allowed
Negation is allowed	Negation is allowed
- Landau's Obligatory control → Non-finite clause	- Subjunctive-like properties → Finite clause

Kouwenberg 1990, pp.44-45

Partial Control

Dependent tense / Abstract agreement / PRO

Subjunctives

Dependent tense/Overt agreement/*pro* & lexical DP

- Behavior seen from wh-extraction and anaphor tests is expected
- There is a point in keeping the finite/non-finite distinction & *pro*/PRO distinction



The case of *pa/pou*-purposive in Pp & HC

They are prepositions and not Complementizers → Select for « finite » or « non-finite » complements (Sterlin 1989, Koopman & Lefebvre 1981 for HC | Lefebvre & Therrien 2007 for Pp)

Papiamentu	Lefebvre & Therrien 2007, p.220	Haitian creole	Koopman & Lefebvre 1981, p.203
Mari _i a bai ‘Job Centre’ pa PRO _i /e _{i/j} buska trabou Mary PERF go Job Centre PA PRO/3SG find work “Mary went to the job Centre to find work”		Mari _i te bezwen eskot pu PRO _i /I _{i/j} te reparti Mary PERF need money pu PRO/3SG PST go-back “Mary needed money to go back”	
Preposition <i>pa</i> “para” – non-finite complements		Preposition <i>pou</i> “pour” – non-finite complements	
- Covert subject is controlled - Future-oriented - Perfective/Past marker <i>a</i> allowed - Negation allowed		- Covert subject is controlled - Future-oriented - Perfective/Past marker <i>te</i> allowed - Negation allowed	
Conjunction <i>pa</i> “para que” – finite complements		Conjunction <i>pou</i> “pour que” – finite complements	
- Overt lexical subject is free - Future-oriented - Perfective/Past marker <i>a</i> allowed - Negation allowed		- Overt lexical subject is free - Future-oriented - Perfective/Past marker <i>te</i> allowed - Negation allowed	



Justifying the distinction finite/non-finite

1. Finite/non-finite distinction more difficult to warrant because :
 - Can't test negation scope for purposive complement
 - Can't test TMA marking because obligatory control and subjunctive clauses can both have perfective/past marker (independent temporal reference)

Partial Control	Dependent tense / Abstract agreement / PRO
Subjunctives	Dependent tense / Overt agreement / <i>pro</i> & lexical DP
2. Most important property is that of referentiality :
 - Anaphoric PRO and free lexical DP/arbitrary *pro* are always in complementary distribution
3. While in the case of purposive complements is it more difficult to justify a finite/non-finite distinction, all complement structures we reanalyzed fit Koopman's working definition of finiteness



Mufwene & Dijkhoff's objections

1. **Issue** : ~~Circuitous to apply wh-extraction test to determine whether a clause contains an infinitive/inflection on the verb & Anaphor test does not work for complements of intransitive verb~~

Proposal : Examine TMA marking, negation and **referentiality properties** (anaphoric null subject (PRO) and free lexical DP in complementary distribution)

2. **Issue** : Invoking embeddedness and subjectlessness to define an infinitival clause is arbitrary.

Proposal : Investigate the relevant HC and Pp examples



Finite subjectless main clauses & embedded clauses

1. **Issue** : There are main clauses that are subjectless but finite (HC)
2. **Proposal** : Main clauses that are finite do have an empty Comp but also **a non-referential null subject [expletive pro-drop property]**, as opposed to anaphoric null subject in embedded clauses.
3. **Issue** : There are embedded clauses that are subjectless and finite (marginal cases in Pp)
4. **Proposal** : Embedded clauses that are finite simply exemplify the pro-drop property of Papiamentu [**anaphoric pro-drop property**] (Hofherr 2006, p.236).
5. Motivates keeping the distinction pro/PRO
6. Revision of Koopman's assumption : Infinitival constructions correspond to embedded sentences with a null subject and an empty COMP

“Infinitival constructions in HC and Pp correspond to obligatory control clauses and CP/TP deficient clauses ”

?Korda yama mi ora PRO yega, tende?
 ‘Remember [to] call me when [you] arrive, hear?’¹⁸
 Ora bo tata bin, PRO ta mira.
 time you father come [we] be/DUR see
 ‘When your father comes/gets home, we’ll see.’
 Mufwene & Dijkhoff 1989

[PRO] ge yun problem.
 [it] have one problem
 ‘There is a problem.’
 [PRO] sable ža vini.
 [it] seem John come[-COMPLETIVE]
 (i) ‘John seems to have come’
 (ii) ‘It seems that John came’
 [PRO] fe fræt.
 [it] make cold
 ‘It is cold.’ Mufwene & Dijkhoff 1989



Mufwene & Dijkhoff's objections

1. **Issue :** ~~Circuitous to apply wh-extraction test to determine whether a clause contains an infinitive/inflection on the verb & Anaphor test does not work for complements of intransitive verb~~

Proposal : Examine TMA marking, negation and referentiality properties (anaphoric null subject (PRO) and free lexical DP in complementary distribution)

2. **Issue :** ~~Invoking embeddedness and subjectlessness to define an infinitival clause is arbitrary.~~

Proposal : Embeddedness and subjectlessness are properties/consequences of obligatory control clauses & CP/IP-deficient clauses which are infinitives in HC and Pp



Conclusion

1. Reanalyze the data presented in Mufwene & Dijkhoff's 1989 article on Haitian creole (HC) and Papiamentu (Pp) in view of new analyses regarding the notion of finiteness.
 - Tentatively, non-finite clauses represent obligatory control clauses and CP/IP-deficient clauses in Pp and Haitian creole
2. Is there really no finite/non-finite distinction in Atlantic Creoles?
 - Yes: Finite / non-finite distinction in Atlantic Creoles related to the subject licensing and referentiality patterns
 - But: while being decisive markers of finiteness in HC *pou*-Comp complements, TMA marking and negation scope are not in Pp's complements and in HC *pou*-purposive complements.
3. Is Koopman's definition of finiteness viable given our reanalysis?
 - Yes/No: Koopman's definition is just the consequence of the properties of finiteness we have shown in the Atlantic Creoles.
4. Can we really do away with the pro/PRO distinction for HC and Pp?
 - Not really: Keeping the distinction between pro/PRO in Pp and HC is relevant, and warranted due to their respective pro-drop properties



Looking further

1. Explore the non-finite properties of HC *v/é*-complement « Mari *v/é* I vini »
 - Mittwoch (1990) bare-VP // Adger (2007) CP/TP-deficient clauses
2. Expand this analysis to the other creoles examined in Mufwene & Dijkhoff (1989) and to other French-based Creoles
3. Propose more tests for finiteness for languages missing inflectional morphology
4. Explore the pro-drop properties of Atlantic Creoles



Thank you! 😊



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